

Asad Ikram

MSc Data Analytics (Distinction), University of Portsmouth · Chevening Scholar 2024/25
Applicant, Research Assistant / PhD Student, Geography of Code group, Corvinus University of Budapest
Lahore, Pakistan · +44 7482 376417 · asad.ikram53@gmail.com · LinkedIn: linkedin.com/in/asad-ikram98 · GitHub: github.com/asadfix · web-scraping-guide.com

PROFILE

Researcher and data engineer working on social media data: how people behave on platforms, and what platform traces can and cannot measure. I bring computational methods to social questions (an MSc dissertation that became a methods paper on measuring opinion across platforms), eight years of coding, modelling and data wrangling on large multilingual web data, and hands-on work with agentic and generative AI. I want to use GitHub, LinkedIn and other trace data to study how AI changes software work and who gains from it, a change I am part of as a developer from Pakistan who entered global software work through a freelance platform.

WHAT THE POSITION ASKS FOR

Computational methods for social questions	Cross-platform study of public reaction to UK economic policy (about 279,000 posts, four platforms); paper with Dr Ella Haig treating each platform as a survey mode; discourse study at M+C Saatchi Fluency (BERTopic codebook, versioned LLM tagging).
Coding, modelling and data wrangling	Python and SQL daily; competitor-intelligence models on 15 markets of multilingual data at Dubizzle Labs; OCR and backfill models at Fix.com; fine-tuned BERT-family classifiers.
Networks, econometrics, databases	Databases and layered warehouses (PostgreSQL, Redshift, Athena, Apache Iceberg). Applied statistics and simulation; not yet trained in econometrics or formal network science.
Agentic and generative AI	Built a self-healing crawler agent and a crawler-builder agent at Fluency; lead a team building an LLM labelling cascade at Artemis AI; use AI coding assistants in my own work.

RESEARCH

Ikram, A. and Haig, E. "Is the Platform Part of the Measurement? A Protocol and Simulation Study for Cross-Platform Equivalence of Machine-Labelled Policy Sentiment." Paper, being posted to arXiv; ICWSM submission planned. Treats each platform as a survey mode and applies generalizability theory, measurement invariance and differential item functioning, and score linking to machine-labelled text. I built the simulation: with known ground truth, pooling platform scores at face value gives the wrong sign of daily aggregate sentiment on roughly a quarter of days, from measurement differences alone. *No peer-reviewed publications to date.*

EDUCATION

Sep 2024 - Sep 2025 awarded 8 Dec 2025	MSc Data Analytics, Distinction. University of Portsmouth, United Kingdom. Chevening Scholar. Credit-weighted average 70.5/100; master's project 78/100. Supervisor: Dr Ella Haig. Modules included Big Data and Machine Learning, Intelligent Data and Text Analytics, Explainable AI and Data Management. Dissertation: <i>Cross-Platform Sentiment Analysis of Public Reaction to UK Economic Policies</i> . About 279,000 public posts from X/Twitter, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, under university ethics approval (TETHIC-2025-111094). Fine-tuned BERT against BiLSTM and lexicon baselines; 200 posts hand-labelled; McNemar and bootstrap tests, chi-square tests across topics, Prophet forecasting.
Aug 2017 - Jan 2022	BS Computer Science. National University of Computer and Emerging Sciences (FAST-NUCES), Pakistan. Courses included Probability and Statistics, Linear Algebra, Calculus I and II, Numerical Methods, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, Database Systems and Applied Machine Learning.

EXPERIENCE

Dec 2024 - present part-time, remote	Data Engineer , M+C Saatchi Fluency, London. Social media analysis for global brands (consumer goods, automotive, sport, e-commerce, health) and UK government. - Analyst on a twelve-month discourse study (100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions): BERTopic codebook, versioned LLM tagging. - Social data collection, labelling and tagging, text and sentiment analysis with AI/ML, forum sourcing and pipeline architecture; a weekly pipeline of 2.2 million rows. - Built a self-healing agent that diagnoses a broken forum crawler, regenerates it and tests it on live pages, and a builder agent that creates new crawlers, across a fleet of 64; secured with prompt fencing and approval gates, and I approve each merge.
2025 - present part-time	Co-Founder and Chief Technology Officer , Artemis AI, United Kingdom. Social-media intelligence for creators and businesses. Lead a team of five across models, AI/ML, deployment, app development and design; take part in pitching.

	- Platform on AWS: Meta Graph API collectors, an Apache Iceberg warehouse, a three-tier labelling cascade (own NLP models, then DeepSeek, then Claude when confidence is low) and image and video understanding; 48 models in the agreed architecture. - Core collection and labelling run weekly; an AI advisor, crisis alerts and further models are in build for the beta on 15 December 2026. Evaluation is being designed around human-labelled data.
Feb 2022 - Aug 2024 full-time	Associate Software Engineer, then Data Engineer, then Senior Data Engineer , Dubizzle Labs (Dubizzle, Bayut, Zameen, OLX), Lahore. Promoted twice in about two and a half years. - Data modelling and machine learning for competitor-intelligence dashboards: what people discussed, how much volume each site carried, and what worked on each platform and in which region. - Designed the company's first web-scraping architecture on AWS: 15 markets, English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi; led a team of three engineers in scraping and data warehousing. Owned a data-warehousing product end to end.
May 2023 - present contract, remote	Data Engineer (contract) , Fix.com, Canada. OCR-based machine learning to parse parts catalogues from PDFs; models to backfill missing parts data; since June 2026, sole designer and operator of the crawler platform (about 10 million rows across 82 datasets).
2018 - 2026 remote	Other data engineering work. Lead Data Engineer, VendueTech, Ireland (2025: Azure-to-AWS migration, team of three); Data Engineer, Prefe, Milan (2024); CXG, Dubai (production crawlers, pytest QA); web-scraping architecture for a US start-up and businesses in the Netherlands, Lithuania and Germany; freelance on Fiverr since 2018 during my BS (300+ completed orders).

SKILLS

Coding	Python (pandas, Scrapy, PyTorch, FastAPI, pytest), SQL, PySpark; Git, GitHub and CI.
Data and databases	Collection from APIs and the open web at scale; cleaning, deduplication, joins and validation; PostgreSQL, Redshift, Athena, DynamoDB, Apache Iceberg; AWS, Docker, Kubernetes.
Modelling and statistics	Hypothesis tests (McNemar, chi-square), bootstrap, Prophet forecasting; simulation with known ground truth; generalizability theory, measurement invariance and DIF, score linking; validating machine and LLM labels against human-labelled sets.
NLP and AI	Fine-tuning encoder classifiers (BERT, XLM-R, DistilBERT, DeBERTa-v3); LLM-assisted labelling (Claude, DeepSeek); OCR, CLIP and Whisper; BERTopic; LIME and integrated gradients; building AI agents; AI coding assistants (Claude Code, OpenAI Codex), where I write the specification and tests and decide what merges.

AWARDS, COMMUNITY AND LANGUAGES

Chevening	Chevening Scholar 2024/25 (UK Government's global scholarship, which funded the MSc), awarded for helping students and junior colleagues into freelance and remote careers and for a proposed cross-platform social media analytics system to give government evidence of public opinion.
Community	Author and maintainer of web-scraping-guide.com (since May 2026), a free public guide to web data collection. Helped university students start freelance careers and junior colleagues at Dubizzle into remote work; two of them got remote jobs.
Languages	Urdu (native); English (working language; MSc taught and assessed in English, IELTS 6.5).

REFEREES

Dr Ella Haig , Associate Professor in AI, School of Computing, University of Portsmouth. Ella.Haig@port.ac.uk . MSc dissertation supervisor and co-author.	Dr Fahad Ahmad , Senior Lecturer, Centre for Cybercrime and Economic Crime, University of Portsmouth. Fahad.Ahmad@port.ac.uk . Taught and assessed me on the MSc.
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